

BREAK INTO AEROSPACE

Aircraft Leasing Specialist

Subdomain Interview Preparation Guide

Targeted for the 2025–2026 Recruitment Cycle

What This Document Covers: Aircraft leasing is simultaneously the most financially consequential and the most least publicly understood sector in commercial aviation. At its broadest, the term encompasses the full spectrum of arrangements under which airlines operate aircraft they do not own — operating leases in which an airline pays a monthly rent and returns the aircraft at the end of the lease term, finance leases in which ownership transfers to the lessee, sale-leaseback transactions in which an airline sells its owned fleet to a lessor and immediately leases it back, wet leases in which the aircraft comes with crew, maintenance, and insurance (ACMI), and the portfolio management, asset remarketing, and maintenance reserve management activities that allow lessors to recycle aircraft through multiple operators over a 25-year economic life. At its most specific, aircraft leasing is the discipline of structuring, negotiating, documenting, and managing the legal and financial contracts that govern an airline's use of an aircraft it does not own — contracts that must address the asset's value across multiple decades, multiple operators, multiple jurisdictions, multiple maintenance events, and multiple market cycles, while satisfying the requirements of aviation authorities, lenders, insurers, and international tax frameworks.

The commercial challenges that define this sector are genuinely complex. The lease must correctly price the residual value of an aircraft type over a 10–12 year operating lease term — a valuation that depends on the future demand for the type, the competitive landscape of aircraft production, the fuel efficiency trajectory of alternative types, and the maintenance status of the specific aircraft at lease return. The maintenance provisions embedded in the lease — the reserves collected from the airline during the lease term to fund the major maintenance events that will be required — must be sized to cover the actual cost of a heavy maintenance check, an engine performance restoration shop visit, and a landing gear overhaul, all of which will be performed under different conditions by different maintenance providers at different future dates. The documentation must be enforceable in the airline's jurisdiction, the lessor's jurisdiction, and the jurisdiction in which the aircraft is registered — three potentially different legal systems, with different approaches to security interests in moveable property, different recognition of the Cape Town Convention, and different requirements for deregistration and export at lease end. And the entire contractual structure — maintenance reserves, end-of-lease redelivery conditions, subleasing rights, total loss and insurance provisions, default remedies — must remain commercially viable across the full range of outcomes the airline might encounter: growth, contraction, restructuring, and bankruptcy.

The employer landscape spans the major independent lessors who collectively own and manage over 50% of the world's commercial jet fleet (AerCap — the world's largest with over 3,000 aircraft — Air Lease Corporation, SMBC Aviation Capital, Avolon, BBAM, GECAS legacy assets, Nordic Aviation Capital for regional aircraft, BOC Aviation, ICBC Leasing, CDB Aviation, and the China-based lessors that have grown to represent a major ownership share), the captive lessors associated with major airlines (Air France-KLM's Regourd Aviation assets, Lufthansa's leasing activities), the regional aircraft specialists (Nordic Aviation Capital, Chorus Aviation Capital, Fly Leasing for narrowbody fleets), the aircraft trading platforms (IBA Group, AVAC, Collateral Verifications), the law firms that document and execute leasing transactions (Clifford Chance, Allen & Overy, Norton Rose Fulbright, Vedder Price, Pillsbury Winthrop in aviation finance), the appraisal firms that provide independent aircraft valuations (AVAC, mba Aviation, BK Associates, Collateral Verifications, Meriax, AVITAS), the asset management platforms that manage third-party aircraft portfolios (ORIX Aviation, Carlyle Aviation Partners, Castlelake), and the lenders who finance aircraft acquisitions and lessor portfolio growth (major bank aviation finance practices at BNP Paribas, HSBC, Société Générale, Citibank Aviation, and the Ex-Im Bank and export credit agencies that support new aircraft deliveries).

The technical baseline is shared across all of these employers — the economics of the operating lease, the legal architecture of the Cape Town Convention, the maintenance cycle of a CFM56-powered narrowbody — but the specific transactional challenges, the negotiating context, and the career trajectory differ substantially between a junior lease analyst at AerCap and a portfolio management associate at a regional aircraft fund.

PART I: WHAT AIRCRAFT LEASING ACTUALLY LOOKS FOR

By Level

Intern / Graduate

At entry level, aircraft leasing employers are not primarily screening for deep aviation finance expertise — they are screening for strong analytical foundations (financial modelling, legal document comprehension, accounting and tax literacy, or commercial contract analysis), combined with the specific intellectual quality that the leasing sector most values: the ability to manage sustained complexity across multiple simultaneous transactions, each with its own commercial terms, legal requirements, and counterparty dynamics.

This last quality is particularly important in leasing because the transactional volume at a major lessor is high and the documentation is dense. A junior analyst at AerCap or Air Lease Corporation may be tracking several dozen active lease negotiations simultaneously, each with its own status, open commercial points, and critical path dependencies. The analyst who can hold this complexity without losing track of individual transaction details — who maintains a clear picture of which leases are at heads-of-terms stage, which are in final documentation, and which have open regulatory approval conditions — is demonstrating the operational discipline that the sector requires even from its most junior participants.

Graduate interviews at major lessors typically involve a combination of financial modelling competency (can the candidate construct a basic lease rate factor calculation or a net present value analysis of a lease versus buy decision?), legal document literacy (can the candidate identify the key commercial terms in a standard operating lease agreement and explain what each protects?), and aviation market awareness (does the candidate understand the difference between a narrowbody, a widebody, and a regional jet, and can they name the major aircraft types currently in production?). At law firms with aviation finance practices, the screen focuses more on transactional legal competency — the candidate's understanding of secured lending, asset-backed financing structures, and cross-border transaction documentation.

Mid-Level (Associate, Senior Associate, ~3–8 years)

At mid-level, aircraft leasing interviews become transaction-specific and counterparty-focused. The sector's defining challenge at mid-level is simultaneous complexity management: not the analysis of any individual lease provision, but the management of the full transaction from initial term sheet through executed documentation — tracking the interdependencies between the commercial terms, the legal conditions precedent, the regulatory approvals, the insurance requirements, and the physical aircraft delivery.

The specific question that most reliably reveals mid-level leasing depth is about the difficult scenario: “your airline lessee has filed for Chapter 11 bankruptcy protection in the US, and you have two aircraft currently on lease to them with 18 months remaining on each lease — walk me through what your rights are as the lessor, what the Section 1110 timeline requires, what the options are for each aircraft, and how you would prioritise the redelivery versus restructured lease decision.” The candidate who can reason through the Section 1110 60-day election period, the lessee's obligation to perform or reject, the lessor's priority claim status as a secured creditor, the remarketing options for the aircraft type in the current market, and the maintenance reserve balance implications of a mid-term lease termination is demonstrating the transactional and commercial depth that hiring managers at major lessors specifically assess.

Senior (VP, Director, Managing Director)

At senior level, aircraft leasing interviews assess the ability to make and defend the portfolio and strategic commercial decisions that determine whether a lessor's book of business is profitable across a market cycle. The senior leasing professional — whether a head of marketing, a chief risk officer, or a portfolio management director — is the person who decides which airline credits are acceptable for direct placements versus syndicated risk, which aircraft types belong in the lessor's core portfolio versus are held opportunistically, and how the maintenance reserve structure should be calibrated for a given airline's maintenance programme and regulatory environment.

The distinguishing credential at senior level is having managed a significant portfolio event from origination through resolution — a defaulted lessee, an aircraft remarketing campaign in a depressed market, a major airline customer's restructuring that required simultaneous management of a dozen aircraft across multiple legal jurisdictions. Professionals who have done this, and who can describe the specific commercial judgements they made and how those judgements were tested by events, have experience that is genuinely formative and increasingly valued as the lessors' portfolios age and the next market disruption approaches.

Hands-On Experience and Domain Knowledge Treated as Strong Signals

- **The Cape Town Convention and the International Registry — the treaty that transformed aircraft finance security.** The Convention on International Interests in Mobile Equipment (Cape Town, 2001) and its Aircraft Protocol are the international legal framework that allow aircraft lessors and lenders to register an international interest in an airframe, engine, or helicopter, and to enforce that interest across contracting states without relying on local law. Understanding what the Cape Town Convention provides — the priority scheme that makes a registered international interest enforceable against subsequent creditors and the insolvency estate of a defaulting lessee, the self-help remedies (deregistration, export, transfer of possession) available to a creditor upon default, and the Alternative A insolvency provisions that create a waiting period and priority claim for aircraft lessors in contracting states that have adopted them — is the foundational legal literacy that every aircraft leasing professional must have. The International Registry at Kildonan, Ireland is the electronic registration system through which international interests are registered and searched. Professionals who have registered and de-registered international interests, who understand the priority search mechanics, and who know which major aviation states have adopted Alternative A are demonstrating a specific and practically important legal competency.
- **Operating lease documentation — the key commercial provisions and what each protects.** The standard aircraft operating lease is a 50–150 page document (depending on complexity and the drafting approach of the parties' counsel) that allocates between lessor and lessee the economic risks and obligations associated with the aircraft over the lease term. The key provisions that every leasing professional must understand at a substantive level: the maintenance reserves structure (the per-flight-hour and per-cycle rates paid into reserve accounts that fund heavy maintenance events — airframe, engine, landing gear, and APU — at the end of the lease); the end-of-lease redelivery conditions (the maintenance status, configuration, and documentation package the aircraft must meet when returned — the number of hours and cycles remaining to the next major maintenance event, the paint and interior condition, the completeness of the back-to-birth technical records); the total loss provisions (how loss is defined, what insurance proceeds are payable, and how the lessor's security interest is preserved); the default and remedies provisions (the events of default — payment failure, insolvency, regulatory non-compliance — and the lessor's remedies upon default — termination, repossession, and the enforcement of the maintenance reserve balance); and the sublease and assignment provisions (whether the lessee can sublease the aircraft to another operator, and what conditions apply). Professionals who have negotiated these provisions — who understand what the airline wants and why, and what the lessor must protect and why — are demonstrating the transactional depth that senior lease management roles require.
- **Lease rate factors and aircraft valuation — how monthly rent is priced and how it changes across the market cycle.** The lease rate factor is the ratio of the monthly lease rent to the aircraft's market value, expressed as a percentage — a narrowbody leased at a monthly rent of \$350,000 against a market value of \$50 million has a lease rate factor of 0.70%. Understanding how lease rate factors are set — the relationship to the lessor's cost of funds, the competitive placement environment for the specific aircraft type, the credit quality of the lessee, the term of the lease, and the maintenance reserve credit provided — is the commercial pricing competency that every lessor's marketing team requires. Aircraft valuation has two components: the current market value (the price at which an aircraft would sell between willing buyers and sellers in an arm's length transaction) and the base value (a longer-term normalised value that abstracts from short-term market conditions). Understanding the relationship between these two values — how they diverge in boom and bust cycles, and what drives the divergence — and the methodology used by the three main appraisal firms (AVAC, mba Aviation, and BK Associates) is the valuation literacy that portfolio managers and risk officers require.
- **Engine lease and engine management — the component most important to aircraft value and most complex to manage.** The engines represent approximately 40–50% of a narrowbody aircraft's total asset value, and their maintenance status — specifically the time remaining before the next performance restoration shop visit, the workscope performed at the last shop visit, and the remaining cycles on the life-limited parts — is the primary driver of the aircraft's maintenance-adjusted value at lease return. Engine management in a leasing context involves: understanding the maintenance programme for the engine type (CFM56-5B for the A320 family, CFM56-7B for the 737 NG family, LEAP-1A and LEAP-1B for the neo/MAX family, GTF for the A220 and A320neo), setting the engine maintenance reserves to fund the shop visit at the correct rate, reconciling the airline's reported engine utilisation against the reserve

accruals, and managing the shop visit workscope selection when the engine is inducted — the trade between a full performance restoration (more expensive, delivers more on-wing time before the next shop visit) and a minimum workscope (less expensive, delivers less time). Professionals who have managed a significant engine portfolio through a maintenance event cycle — who have overseen shop visit decisions, workscope selections, and LLP replacement negotiations with the MRO — are demonstrating the asset management depth that technical asset management roles require.

- **Airline credit assessment — evaluating the financial health and operational risk of an airline lessee.** The airline industry is one of the most cyclically volatile in the global economy, and a lease signed with a financially healthy airline can become a distressed credit within 18 months if fuel prices spike, a pandemic occurs, or the airline's home market deteriorates. The credit assessment of an airline lessee — used to set lease rate terms, determine whether security deposits are required, and decide whether to maintain or reduce the airline's share of the lessor's portfolio — requires understanding the airline's revenue model (network carrier, low-cost carrier, ultra-low-cost carrier, charter operator), its cost structure (fuel hedging programme, labour agreements, maintenance outsourcing arrangements), its liquidity position (cash on hand, undrawn credit facilities, near-term debt maturities), its fleet strategy (owned versus leased split, fleet age, type mix), and its regulatory and operating risk (route authority stability, aircraft utilisation restrictions, slots and bilateral air services agreement exposure). Professionals who have developed and defended airline credit assessments in a committee setting — who have forecast an airline's maintenance reserve draw rates, modelled its liquidity under stress, and set appropriate security deposit levels — are demonstrating the credit risk competency that senior leasing portfolio and risk roles require.
- **Aircraft technical records management — the documentation that establishes the aircraft's maintenance history and airworthiness.** When an aircraft is delivered to a new lessee or returned from a lessee to a lessor, the completeness and accuracy of its technical records — the back-to-birth documentation that traces every maintenance event, component replacement, modification, and airworthiness directive compliance back to the manufacturer's delivery — is one of the primary determinants of the aircraft's residual value and remarketing potential. An aircraft with complete, organised, and legible records is worth materially more than an aerodynamically identical aircraft with missing or disorganised records, because the next buyer or lessee must be confident that the aircraft's maintenance history is verifiable. Understanding what constitutes a complete records package (the Aircraft Logbooks, the Engine Logbooks, the Component Historical Records for life-limited parts, the Modification and AD Compliance Records, and the Weight and Balance Documentation), what records deficiencies are commercially material versus administratively curable, and what the standard redelivery condition schedule requires in terms of records completeness are the technical records competencies that every lease management professional must have.
- **Remarketing and placement — finding the next lessee when an aircraft is returned.** When a lease expires or is terminated, the lessor must place the aircraft with a new lessee, convert it to cargo operation, part it out for components, or sell it — usually within the shortest possible off-lease period, since every month without a rent-paying lessee is direct value destruction. The remarketing process requires: an accurate assessment of the aircraft type's current placement market (which airlines are actively seeking the type, at what lease rate, and with what redelivery requirements), a maintenance readiness assessment (what transition maintenance is required to meet the new lessee's entry requirements, and how long will it take), a decision on the lease structure (direct operating lease, leaseback, short-term placement while the long-term market is found), and a documentation package that can be executed quickly once terms are agreed. Professionals who have led a remarketing campaign — who have managed the transition from an expiring lease through the physical redelivery, the maintenance transition, and the execution of the new lease — are demonstrating the full-cycle asset management competency that portfolio directors require.
- **Aircraft delivery and redelivery process — the physical and legal milestones of lease commencement and termination.** The delivery of an aircraft from lessor to lessee, and its redelivery at lease end, are the two most operationally intensive moments in the lease relationship. Delivery requires: a pre-delivery inspection (typically a 2–5 day process in which the lessee's technical team and independent inspector verify the aircraft's configuration, maintenance status, and documentation against the lease's delivery conditions), the execution of the delivery acceptance certificate, the transfer of insurance and operator

responsibility, the registration of the aircraft on the lessee's air operator certificate, and the implementation of the aircraft on the lessee's approved maintenance programme. Redelivery requires the same process in reverse, with the additional complexity that the aircraft must be inspected against the redelivery condition schedule — every item of which, if not compliant, is either remediated by the lessee or deducted from the security deposit. Understanding the commercial mechanics of the delivery and redelivery process — specifically the inspection rights, the dispute resolution process for condition discrepancies, and the maintenance reserve reconciliation and payment — is the operational competency that lease administration and portfolio management professionals require.

How Aircraft Leasing Interviews Differ from General Aviation Finance and from Generic Finance Roles

- **The asset matters as much as the paper.** In most finance disciplines, the transaction is the product — the loan is originated, the bond is placed, the deal is closed. In aircraft leasing, the transaction is only the beginning of an asset relationship that will last 10–15 years and will require continuous management. The lease administrator who does not understand the aircraft — its maintenance cycle, its utilisation characteristics, its residual value sensitivity to configuration — cannot identify when the airline is over-utilising the engines relative to the reserve accruals or when the missing records will become a remarketing problem. The professionals who thrive in aircraft leasing are those who are genuinely curious about the asset — who want to understand why a CFM56-5B shop visit costs more than a CFM56-7B shop visit, why a high-cycle narrowbody depreciates faster than a low-cycle one, and why the winglet configuration of a 737-800 affects its placement market relative to a non-winglet aircraft.
- **The legal and commercial domains are inseparable.** In most finance roles, the legal documentation is produced by lawyers and reviewed by bankers at a level sufficient to understand the economic terms. In aircraft leasing, the legal provisions of the operating lease directly determine the lessor's economic outcome — the maintenance reserve rates set in Schedule 3 determine how much cash the lessor receives to fund future heavy maintenance; the redelivery conditions in Schedule 5 determine how much the aircraft is worth when it comes back; the Cape Town registration mechanics determine whether the lessor can repossess the aircraft efficiently if the lessee defaults. The leasing professional who cannot read and negotiate lease documentation — who treats legal provisions as something to delegate to counsel without understanding the commercial consequence — is missing the most important analytical competency in the role.
- **The market cycle is always present.** Aircraft leasing is a cyclical business, and the placement decisions made at the top of the cycle — leasing aircraft to marginal credits at aggressive rates on long terms in a supply-constrained market — determine the portfolio losses that will be incurred when the cycle turns. The professionals who have managed aircraft portfolios through a full market cycle — the post-2008 airline consolidation, the 2020 pandemic fleet grounding, the post-pandemic narrowbody shortage — have experience that cannot be replicated in a classroom, and interviews will probe whether the candidate has genuinely processed the lessons of the cycle they lived through.
- **The counterparty relationship is long-term.** A lease placed with a major network carrier may run for 12 years, involve three aircraft types, and generate 144 monthly rent payments before the relationship concludes. The lessor who treats each transaction as a standalone deal — rather than as one element of a multi-decade commercial relationship — will optimise individual transactions at the expense of the relationship economics. The professionals who understand how to balance the short-term commercial terms of an individual transaction against the long-term value of the airline relationship — and who can articulate the trade-offs they have made — are demonstrating the commercial maturity that senior leasing roles require.
- **Jurisdiction complexity is the default operating environment.** A single aircraft lease may involve a lessor incorporated in Ireland (for tax reasons), an aircraft registered in Bermuda or Cayman Islands (for regulatory reasons), an airline operating in Southeast Asia (for commercial reasons), engines manufactured in the US and France, a lease governed by English law, financing provided by a consortium of Asian banks, and insurance placed in London. Managing this jurisdictional complexity — ensuring that the lessor's security interest is valid and enforceable in each jurisdiction, that the tax structuring is defensible in each relevant tax authority's view, and that the insurance proceeds will be payable to the right party under the governing law of the policy — is the structural complexity that distinguishes

aircraft leasing from most other asset finance disciplines and that the interview will specifically probe.

PART II: 20 SPECIFIC PREP TASKS

INTERN / GRADUATE

1. Understand the aircraft leasing ecosystem — the lessor, the lessee, the lender, the insurer, and how they interconnect 4–5 hours

Skill: The system-level map of the aircraft finance industry that frames every professional role within it

Why the field cares: Aircraft leasing is a financial system, not just a series of bilateral contracts. The lessor needs the lender's debt to fund the aircraft acquisition; the lender needs the insurance proceeds to recover if the aircraft is lost; the insurer needs the Cape Town registration to confirm its priority; the lessee needs the aircraft to generate the revenue that funds the lease rent; and the lessor needs the rent to service the debt. A candidate who understands only the lease contract is missing the context within which every leasing decision is made. The lease administrator who does not understand that the lessor's debt covenants require the aircraft to be insured for at least 110% of the outstanding loan balance cannot correctly manage an insurance renewal dispute. The marketing professional who does not understand that the lender requires a direct agreement with the lessee before releasing the aircraft cannot correctly sequence the conditions precedent to delivery. Understanding the ecosystem — not as background information, but as the constraint environment within which every commercial decision is evaluated — is the aircraft leasing professional mindset.

Done signal: You can describe the aircraft leasing ecosystem's five major participants — lessor, lessee, lender, insurer, and aviation authority — and for each, state what it must provide to the system, what its primary commercial constraints are, and one specific interaction between it and each of the other participants. You can explain why a change in the lessee's insurance coverage (say, a move to a bare hull value below the lessor's minimum required insured value) would cascade through the lender's consent requirement, the lessor's security position, and the remedies available under the lease.

2. Understand the Cape Town Convention and the International Registry — the legal foundation of aircraft finance security 5–6 hours

Skill: The international legal framework that governs every cross-border aircraft leasing transaction

Why the field cares: The Cape Town Convention and its Aircraft Protocol are the treaty documents that allow lessors to register and enforce international interests in aircraft objects (airframes, aircraft engines, and helicopters) across international borders. Reading the Convention and Protocol — not a summary, the documents themselves — is a minimum preparation step for any aircraft leasing professional, and the interview will reveal whether this has been done. The specific provisions that every leasing professional must understand at the level of their commercial consequences: Article 16 (the creation of international interests and the parties' obligations), Article 29 (the priority of registered interests over subsequently registered or unregistered interests), Article 30 (the effects of insolvency), the Alternative A insolvency provisions of the Aircraft Protocol (the 60-day waiting period and the conditions for preserving the creditor's remedies), and the registration and search procedures at the International Registry. Candidates who have searched the International Registry, who know what information appears on a priority search certificate, and who understand what a consent to registration means are demonstrating the foundational legal literacy that the sector requires.

Done signal: You have read the Cape Town Convention and Aircraft Protocol (available on the UNIDROIT website) and can describe without consulting the documents: what an international interest is and how it is created, what the priority rules are between competing interests, what Alternative A provides for a lessor in an airline insolvency, and what the de-registration power of attorney (DPOA) is and why every aircraft operating lease requires one. You can explain one specific scenario

in which the Cape Town Convention provides a materially better outcome for the lessor than local law alone would provide, and name three major aviation states that have adopted Alternative A.

5–6 hours

3. Understand the operating lease structure — the key commercial terms and what each provision protects

5–6 hours

Skill: The contractual architecture that governs the airline–lessor relationship over the full lease term

Why the field cares: The operating lease agreement is the primary commercial document in aircraft leasing, and understanding it at the level of its specific provisions — not just its general structure — is what distinguishes professionals who can contribute to a transaction from those who cannot. The key provisions: the maintenance reserves structure (the per-flight-hour and per-cycle rates, the eligible maintenance events, the reserve account mechanics, and the supplemental rent top-up provisions for shortfalls); the redelivery conditions schedule (the minimum maintenance return condition, the hour and cycle thresholds, the paint and interior standards, and the records package requirement); the default and remedies provisions (the cure periods, the events of default, and the self-help remedies); and the total loss and insurance provisions (the agreed value, the insurance minimum requirements, the loss payee designation, and the proceeds application). Reading a standard form operating lease — the IATA Standard Ground Handling Agreement is not useful here; a specimen AerCap, Air Lease Corporation, or SMBC form, some of which appear in SEC filings, is the appropriate starting point — is the preparation that the interview will reveal.

Done signal: You have read a complete operating lease agreement or a substantial portion of a publicly available specimen form. You can describe the commercial purpose of: the maintenance reserves schedule and why rates are set at per-flight-hour and per-cycle levels rather than a single monthly amount; the end-of-lease redelivery condition schedule and what “full life” condition means for an airframe versus an engine; the default provision and what cure periods exist before the lessor can terminate the lease; and the total loss insurance requirement and how proceeds are applied between the lessor, the lessee, and any lenders. You can identify three provisions that protect the lessor and three that protect the lessee, and explain the commercial logic of each.

4. Prepare behavioural answers demonstrating transactional discipline, counterparty management, and comfort with legal and commercial complexity

2–3 hours

Skill: The character signals that aircraft leasing employers specifically probe

Why the field cares: Aircraft leasing employers — particularly at the major lessors and aviation finance law firms — assess whether candidates can manage high volumes of simultaneous transactional complexity without losing track of critical details, whether they take a relationship rather than a purely transactional perspective, and whether they engage constructively with the legal and commercial ambiguity that is inherent in cross-border transactions. The stories that are weakest in leasing interviews demonstrate narrow process execution (“I drafted the maintenance reserve schedule”). The strongest demonstrate commercial judgement under pressure (“I identified that the airline’s proposed maintenance reserve rate for the CFM56 engine was 30% below the rate implied by its reported utilisation pattern, recalculated the shortfall exposure over the remaining lease term, and negotiated a supplemental deposit that protected the lessor’s position without terminating a commercially valuable relationship”). The candidate who engages with publicly available information about aircraft leasing transactions — IATA Economic Performance reports, lessor annual reports, airline restructuring filings — and who can discuss them as commercial content rather than business news is demonstrating the sector-engaged maturity that leasing employers look for.

Done signal: Four STAR stories covering: a situation where you managed multiple complex workstreams simultaneously without losing critical details; a time you identified a commercial or legal risk that others had missed and took action to address it; a situation where you managed a difficult counterparty relationship through a commercially contentious negotiation; and a time you learned from a transaction or project that did not go as planned and applied that learning to a subsequent situation. At least two stories involve specific financial, legal, or analytical content that had a mea-

asurable commercial consequence.

2–3 hours

5. Understand aircraft types and their commercial characteristics — the difference between narrowbody, widebody, and regional aircraft and why it matters for leasing

3–4 hours

Skill: The aviation market awareness that grounds every commercial and portfolio decision in the sector

Why the field cares: Aircraft leasing is ultimately an asset management business, and the asset is the aircraft. A leasing professional who cannot distinguish a 737-800 from a 737 MAX 8, who does not know that the A320neo family's LEAP and GTF engines represent a different cost profile from the A320ceo's CFM56, or who cannot explain why widebody residual values are more volatile than narrowbody values is missing the foundational market knowledge that the sector's commercial decisions require. The relevant distinctions: narrowbody aircraft (A320 family, 737 family, and their NEO/MAX successors) are the backbone of the leasing market — high-volume, liquid, short-to-medium-haul aircraft with active placement markets and relatively predictable residual values; widebody aircraft (A330, A350, 777, 787) are less liquid, more exposed to long-haul demand cycles, and more sensitive to individual airline relationships; regional aircraft (ATR, Dash 8, ERJ, CRJ) operate in thinner markets with specialist lessors and more complex maintenance reserve management. Understanding these market segments — and what each implies for lease term, lease rate, redelivery condition standards, and remarketing strategy — is the commercial aviation literacy that leasing interviews specifically probe.

Done signal: You can describe the three major aircraft market segments (narrowbody, widebody, regional) and for each, state the dominant aircraft types currently in production, the typical lease term, the typical lease rate factor range, the primary lessors active in the segment, and one specific leasing challenge that is particular to the segment. You can explain why a 12-year-old A320ceo with CFM56 engines is worth less per seat than a 5-year-old A320neo with LEAP engines, and what the leasing implication of that value difference is for a lessor managing a mixed narrowbody portfolio.

6. Get hands-on with aircraft leasing financial literature — read lessor annual reports, airline filings, and transaction structures

6–8 hours

Skill: Specific commercial engagement with the field's active transactional landscape

Why the field cares: Unlike general finance, where transaction information is largely confidential, aircraft leasing leaves substantial commercial information in the public domain — major lessors publish detailed annual reports describing their portfolios, placement activity, maintenance reserve policies, and aircraft type exposure; airlines disclose their fleet plans and lease terms in SEC filings; and major restructuring and insolvency proceedings produce publicly available court documents that describe the commercial terms of lease renegotiations in detail. Candidates who have read AerCap's most recent annual report, who can describe the portfolio's type composition and the geographic diversification of the lessee base, and who have looked at a major airline's 10-K to understand how it describes its operating lease obligations are demonstrating the specific commercial engagement that generic interest in aviation finance cannot substitute. The IATA Economic Performance of the Airline Industry report, the Cirium fleet data summaries, and the published AVAC and mba appraisal bases are all publicly available and represent the market context for every leasing decision.

Done signal: You have read the most recent annual report of at least two major lessors (AerCap and Air Lease Corporation are the most informative public filers) and can describe without consulting the documents: the portfolio size and composition by aircraft type and age, the geographic distribution of lessees, the average remaining lease term, the cost of funds and its relationship to the lease rate factor, and one specific portfolio management challenge described by management. You have also reviewed one airline's most recent 10-K or annual report and can describe how the airline accounts for its operating leases, what information it provides about remaining lease obligations, and what the fleet composition implies for its maintenance reserve draw profile.

MID-LEVEL (3–8 years)

All graduate tasks still apply. Commercial and legal stories must come from professional transactional contexts. Regulatory and documentation knowledge must extend to specific provisions, not just the framework level.

7. Understand the airline insolvency process and the lessor's rights — Section 1110, Cape Town Alternative A, and the international variation
5–6 hours

Skill: The most commercially consequential risk management scenario in aircraft leasing

Why the field cares: Every aircraft lessor with a meaningful portfolio will eventually have a lessee enter insolvency — the airline industry's cyclical nature makes it inevitable. The lessor's rights in that insolvency, and the actions it must take within defined timeframes to preserve those rights, are the most time-critical and commercially consequential aspects of aircraft leasing portfolio management. In the US, Section 1110 of the Bankruptcy Code provides aircraft lessors with rights that are unique in US insolvency law: the lessee must elect within 60 days of filing whether to perform its obligations under the lease (including curing any payment defaults) or to return the aircraft, and the lessor's right to repossession is not subject to the automatic stay if the lessee fails to perform. Understanding the Section 1110 election mechanics, the cure payment requirements, the lessor's options if the lessee rejects the lease, and the condition in which the aircraft must be returned are the US insolvency competencies that every mid-level leasing professional must have. Internationally, the Cape Town Convention's Alternative A provisions provide an analogous framework for contracting states that have adopted it, with a similar waiting period and performance obligation. Knowing which major aviation states have and have not adopted Alternative A — and what the lessor's rights are under local law in states that have not — is the international portfolio management competency that distinguishes professionals who have managed cross-border insolvency exposures.

Done signal: You can walk through the Section 1110 process from the date of a lessee's Chapter 11 filing through the 60-day election period, the cure payment requirement, and the lessor's remedies if the lessee rejects the lease or fails to perform. You can explain the parallel Cape Town Convention Alternative A framework and name three major aviation states (outside the US) that have adopted Alternative A. You can describe what happens to the maintenance reserve balances in a mid-term lease termination — whether they are applied against arrears, returned to the lessee, or retained by the lessor — and identify what the lease documentation typically provides on this question. You can describe the practical steps a lessor takes in the 72 hours following a lessee's insolvency filing.

8. Understand the maintenance reserve system in depth — rate setting, eligible events, reconciliation, and the commercial disputes that arise
5–6 hours

Skill: The financial mechanism that funds the most significant cost events in the aircraft's life

Why the field cares: Maintenance reserves are the core financial instrument through which aircraft lessors manage the maintenance cost exposure of an operating lease. The reserve rates — expressed as per-flight-hour and per-cycle payments for the airframe, each engine, the landing gear, and the APU — must be set at levels that will fund the actual maintenance events that will occur during the lease term, inflated to the cost level at the time of the event. Setting these rates correctly requires: understanding the maintenance programme for the specific aircraft type (what maintenance events are required, at what intervals, and at what cost), estimating the lessee's future utilisation (flight hours per cycle ratio, which determines whether the airframe or engine reaches its time or cycle limit first), and adjusting for inflation and maintenance cost trends. The commercial disputes that most frequently arise in lease management — the airline that claims its utilisation is lower than the reserve rates anticipated, the lessor that finds the airline has been under-reporting flight hours, the disagreement about whether a specific maintenance event qualifies as an eligible draw from the reserve account — are the practical maintenance reserve management challenges that mid-level professionals must be equipped to handle.

Done signal: You can describe the maintenance reserve rate-setting process for a narrowbody aircraft — identifying the eligible maintenance events (C-checks, 6-year/12-year heavy checks, engine performance restoration shop visits, landing gear overhauls, APU shop visits), the utilisation assumption

5–6 hours

tions required to set the per-flight-hour and per-cycle rates, and the inflation adjustment methodology. You can explain what a maintenance reserve reconciliation involves — the process of comparing actual utilisation against the reserve accrual at mid-lease, identifying shortfalls or surpluses, and negotiating a supplemental rent or credit adjustment. You can describe one commercial dispute about maintenance reserve eligibility — for example, whether a non-scheduled engine shop visit driven by foreign object damage qualifies as an eligible draw — and explain how the lease documentation typically addresses it.

2 hours

9. Prepare a technically specific story about managing a complex aircraft delivery or redelivery — where the standard process encountered a significant complication

Skill: The operational competency that distinguishes professionals who have executed transactions from those who have only analysed them

Why the field cares: Aircraft deliveries and redeliveries are the moments at which the abstract commercial terms of the lease become concrete operational and financial obligations. A redelivery in which the aircraft arrives with engines below the minimum maintenance return condition, missing technical records for a major modification, and interior damage above the contractual allowance is a situation that requires simultaneous management of the technical assessment, the financial exposure calculation, the negotiating position with the lessee, and the timeline pressure of the incoming lessee's delivery expectation. The mid-level professional who has managed a redelivery of this complexity — who can describe the inspector's findings, the commercial exposure, the negotiated resolution, and the documentation of the agreed settlement — is demonstrating the transactional and operational competence that lease management roles require.

Done signal: You have a story about managing a complex aircraft delivery or redelivery — in a professional context — where the standard process encountered a significant complication (a maintenance condition discrepancy, a records deficiency, a disagreement about the contractual standard, a timing delay caused by regulatory approval). The story describes the specific complication, the commercial exposure it created, the approach you took to assess and quantify the issue, the negotiation with the counterparty, and the resolution. The story is specific — it names the aircraft type, the nature of the discrepancy, and the financial outcome — not generic.

4–5 hours

10. Understand the aircraft finance structures used to fund lessor portfolios — ECA financing, capital markets, bank debt, and the ABS structure

Skill: The funding architecture that determines a lessor's cost of funds and its competitive position

Why the field cares: Aircraft lessors fund their aircraft acquisitions through a combination of debt and equity, and the cost and structure of that funding determines the lease rates they can offer and their competitive position against other lessors. The primary funding sources: bank debt (bilateral and syndicated term loans from aviation finance banks, typically with 10–12 year tenors matching the lease term), Export Credit Agency financing (US Ex-Im Bank for Boeing aircraft, European ECA guarantee for Airbus aircraft, typically at below-market rates but with extensive documentation and political exposure), capital markets debt (unsecured bonds issued by major lessors against their general corporate credit, and secured bonds backed by specific aircraft portfolios), and equity (from the lessor's shareholders, which in many cases are financial institutions or sovereign wealth funds). The Aircraft Backed Securitisation (ABS) structure — in which a portfolio of aircraft and their leases is transferred to a special purpose vehicle that issues rated notes against the cash flow — is the primary structured finance tool used to recycle capital from mature portfolios, and understanding its structure (the waterfall, the liquidity facility, the servicer role, and the rating agency stress scenarios) is the structured finance literacy that portfolio management roles at major lessors require.

Done signal: You can describe the four primary funding sources for a major aircraft lessor and, for each, state the typical tenor, the primary advantages and disadvantages from the lessor's perspective, and the key documentation requirement. You can explain how the Ex-Im Bank guarantee affects the all-in cost of an aircraft acquisition and what conditions (US content requirement, sovereign guaran-

4–5 hours

tee in some markets) the guarantee imposes. You can describe the basic structure of an aircraft ABS — the SPV, the series of notes, the liquidity facility, the servicer, and the waterfall — and explain why an airline’s insolvency in an ABS portfolio affects the note payments differently from the way it would affect an unsecured lessor.

4–5 hours

11. Understand the tax structure of aircraft leasing — why Irish lessor platforms dominate, and how Section 110, IFRS 16, and double tax treaties interact

Skill: The tax architecture that explains the organisational structure of global aircraft leasing

Why the field cares: Ireland has become the dominant global hub for aircraft leasing — AerCap, SMBC Aviation Capital, Avolon, BOC Aviation’s European operations, Air Lease Corporation’s European platform, and dozens of smaller lessors are domiciled there — primarily because of Ireland’s tax architecture: the 12.5% corporate tax rate, the extensive network of double taxation treaties (over 70 bilateral tax treaties reducing or eliminating withholding taxes on lease payments), the Section 110 special purpose vehicle regime that allows tax-efficient structured finance, and the regulatory environment of the Irish Aviation Authority and the Central Bank of Ireland. Understanding why leasing companies are structured the way they are — why the aircraft-owning entity is typically an Irish SPV rather than the lessor’s operating company, why the lease payments flow through a specific treaty route, and how IFRS 16 (the accounting standard that requires airlines to capitalise operating lease obligations on their balance sheets) affects the airline’s reported leverage and therefore its credit profile — is the structural awareness that distinguishes professionals who understand the business from those who operate within it without understanding why it is organised as it is.

Done signal: You can explain why Ireland is the dominant jurisdiction for aircraft lessor platforms — naming the three primary structural advantages (tax rate, treaty network, regulatory environment) and explaining the commercial consequence of each. You can describe what a Section 110 special purpose vehicle is and why lessors use SPVs rather than direct aircraft ownership in many transactions. You can explain what IFRS 16 requires airlines to do with their operating lease obligations, how this affects the airline’s reported leverage ratio, and why this change affected the way lessors present the economic advantage of leasing versus buying to airline CFOs.

4–5 hours

12. Build working knowledge of the aircraft remarketing process — from lease expiry through technical inspection to placement and execution

Skill: The asset management cycle that determines whether the lessor recovers full value from its aircraft

Why the field cares: The remarketing of an off-lease or expiring-lease aircraft is the highest-value asset management activity in aircraft leasing, and getting it wrong — accepting a below-market placement because of pressure to reduce the off-lease period, or missing a technical discrepancy in the redelivery inspection that costs more to remedy than the security deposit covers — is a direct loss of portfolio value. The remarketing process involves: a market assessment of the type’s current placement environment (which airlines need the type, at what rates, on what terms, and with what redelivery configuration requirements), a technical assessment of the aircraft’s maintenance status and what transition maintenance is required to meet the incoming lessee’s entry requirements, a commercial decision on the lease structure (full-term operating lease, short-term bridge lease while the market improves, sale to a trader or investor), and the execution of the delivery to the new lessee. Professionals who have led a remarketing campaign — who have managed the market canvas, the technical inspection, the term negotiation, and the delivery — are demonstrating the full-cycle asset management competency that portfolio management roles require.

Done signal: You can describe the remarketing process for a returning narrowbody aircraft — from the 18-month notice period through the technical inspection, the market canvas, the term negotiation, and the delivery to the new lessee — identifying the key decisions at each stage and the information required to make them. You can explain what a “transition maintenance” scope involves for a narrowbody aircraft changing operators — what checks are required, what configuration changes may

be needed, and how long the process typically takes. You can describe how a lessor decides between a short-term and a long-term placement when the long-term market offers a higher rate but requires a 6-month remarketing timeline.

4–5 hours

13. Prepare for a cross-domain aircraft leasing problem under interview conditions — a portfolio stress scenario or a transaction structuring problem with cascading commercial implications

4–6 hours

Skill: Structured leasing transactional thinking under time pressure

Why the field cares: Mid-level and senior aircraft leasing interviews consistently include a cross-domain portfolio or transaction problem — a scenario that requires reasoning across commercial, legal, technical, and financial domains simultaneously. “You have 15 narrowbody aircraft on lease to an airline that has just announced it is entering Chapter 11 bankruptcy protection. Six aircraft have fewer than 12 months remaining on their leases, four are mid-lease with 3–5 years remaining, and five are in the first year of 12-year leases. Walk through your immediate priorities, the Section 1110 election implications for each tranche, the maintenance reserve balances and their implications, the remarketing market for the type, and your recommendation for each aircraft tranche.” The candidate who can trace these implications — insolvency filing → Section 1110 60-day clock → election mechanics by tranche → maintenance reserve reconciliation → remarketing market assessment → portfolio decision by tranche — is demonstrating the connected commercial reasoning that aircraft leasing requires.

Done signal: You can work through a cross-domain aircraft leasing portfolio or transaction problem in under 25 minutes — tracing the commercial and legal implications of a scenario (an airline insolvency, a maintenance event cost overrun, a lease renegotiation demand, or a remarketing market deterioration) through at least three domains (legal rights and remedies, financial exposure and reserve adequacy, remarketing market and pricing, counterparty relationship management). You have practised this for at least two different scenarios. You articulate the key decision at each stage and identify the information you would need to make it.

SENIOR LEVEL (VP, Director, Managing Director)

All mid-level tasks still apply. Legal and transactional knowledge must extend to direct negotiating experience with counterparties. Portfolio knowledge must include direct experience with market cycle management and significant credit events.

14. Prepare to walk through the most commercially significant portfolio management decision you have personally led — the analysis, the recommendation, and the outcome

4–6 hours

Skill: Senior portfolio management judgement demonstrated through a specific and consequential decision

Why the field cares: Senior aircraft leasing professionals are specifically valued for having made significant portfolio management decisions under commercial pressure — for having decided whether to accept a lessee’s proposed lease restructuring or to exercise default remedies, whether to accept a below-market remarketing offer or to carry the aircraft off-lease, whether to hedge the portfolio’s exposure to a weakening airline credit or to increase the position. This experience is genuinely difficult to acquire — most portfolio management professionals operate within frameworks set by more senior colleagues — and the specific judgement exercised in a major portfolio decision, and its outcome, is the professional credential that senior leasing roles most value. The story must demonstrate not just that the decision was made, but that the candidate understood the commercial forces at play, made a specific recommendation with explicit assumptions, and had the experience of seeing those assumptions tested.

Done signal: For one portfolio management decision you personally led — where the commercial stakes were significant and the correct course of action was not obvious — you can describe: the specific situation (the aircraft type, the lessee, the commercial context), the options you identified, the analysis you performed to evaluate them, the recommendation you made and the assumptions

it rested on, the decision that was taken, and what happened subsequently. You can describe which assumptions turned out to be correct, which were wrong, and what you would do differently with the benefit of hindsight. The story is specific — it names the aircraft type, the airline, the commercial stakes — not generic.

4–6 hours

15. Prepare a technically grounded position on one active aircraft leasing frontier — sustainable aviation fuel lease provisions, narrowbody order book supply, or the secondary market for aging widebodies

4–5 hours

Skill: Forward-looking commercial awareness at senior professional depth

Why the field cares: Aircraft leasing in 2025–2026 has several genuine commercial frontiers where the market dynamics are changing rapidly, the contractual frameworks are still evolving, and the decisions being made now will determine portfolio performance in 2030. The narrowbody supply shortage — driven by the production ramp difficulties at Boeing and Airbus, the GTF engine durability issues requiring early shop visits on A320neo family aircraft, and the LEAP engine inspection requirements — has created an unprecedented placement market for existing narrowbodies that is changing the commercial dynamics of lease renewals and remarketing. The secondary market for aging widebodies — particularly the 777-200ER and A330-200 as they age out of major carrier fleets — presents both opportunity (aircraft can be acquired cheaply and placed with emerging market carriers) and risk (the maintenance cost profile of aging widebodies is difficult to reserve for, and the residual value trajectory is uncertain). The evolution of SAF-related lease provisions — how lessors are responding to airline commitments to blended SAF use, whether this affects the engine's maintenance programme and the reserve rate, and what the lessor's exposure is if the SAF supply that the airline's maintenance programme assumed is unavailable — is an active contractual frontier. Senior professionals who can engage at commercial depth with any of these frontiers are demonstrating the forward-looking perspective that the sector's leadership roles require.

Done signal: You have a prepared 3-minute commercial discussion covering one specific frontier — named specifically: the narrowbody supply shortage and what it means for lease rate trajectories, redelivery condition negotiations, and the remarketing market for 10–15 year old A320ceo aircraft; the secondary market for aging widebodies and the underwriting challenges of a portfolio heavy in 777-200ER aircraft; or the SAF-related lease provision evolution and what contractual protections lessors are seeking in new transactions. Your position identifies the specific commercial problem, describes the approaches being taken by the market, and states your view on how the dynamic will resolve.

16. Prepare to lead a technical discussion on an aircraft leasing strategic portfolio decision — fleet type concentration, geographic credit diversification, or direct purchase versus sale-leaseback origination

4–5 hours

Skill: Strategic portfolio decision-making at the commercial level

Why the field cares: Senior aircraft leasing professionals are called on to make or advise on portfolio strategy decisions that have decade-scale commercial and financial consequences. “For a mid-size lessor with a €5 billion portfolio that is currently 70% narrowbody and 30% widebody, with 60% of lessees in Asia-Pacific and 40% in Europe, assess whether to increase the widebody share through a sale-leaseback with a major Gulf carrier at current market terms, or to deploy capital into additional narrowbody commitments with a 3-year delivery tail.” This requires reasoning through: the current and projected placement market for widebodies versus narrowbodies, the credit quality and geographic concentration of the portfolio relative to diversification targets, the execution risk of sale-leaseback versus forward order book commitments, and the impact on the portfolio's cost of funds if the widebody share increases and rating agencies apply a higher risk weight. The senior interview tests whether you can structure this reasoning and arrive at a specific recommendation.

Done signal: You have worked through at least two aircraft leasing portfolio strategy trade-off problems — one involving a fleet type or age mix decision and one involving a geographic or credit

concentration decision. For each, you state the governing constraint, the two or three credible options, the key trade-off, and your recommendation with explicit sensitivities to the assumptions. You can do this in under 10 minutes per scenario, and you can identify which assumptions are most load-bearing for your recommendation.

4–5 hours

17. Understand the aircraft leasing legal documentation in depth — the specific negotiating points that most often produce commercial disputes and how they are resolved

4–5 hours

Skill: The negotiating experience that distinguishes senior leasing professionals from mid-level transactional participants

Why the field cares: Senior aircraft leasing professionals are expected to lead the commercial negotiation of lease documentation — not to delegate it entirely to counsel, but to direct the commercial terms, understand the legal language that implements them, and make the judgements about which points are commercially essential and which are tradeable. The specific provisions that most frequently produce commercial disputes — and that therefore require the most careful drafting and the most experienced negotiation — are the maintenance reserves eligibility provisions (what events qualify for reimbursement, and what workscope is required), the redelivery condition schedule (what “full life” means for each major component, and how shortfalls are compensated), the subleasing consent provisions (what information the lessor requires, what conditions it can impose, and how quickly it must respond), and the return condition compensation provisions (how the cash compensation for a redelivery shortfall is calculated and when it is payable). Professionals who have negotiated these provisions across multiple transactions — who know what the airline’s standard objection is to the lessor’s proposed maintenance reserve eligibility language, and how the market has evolved on this point — are demonstrating the negotiating experience that senior lease management roles require.

Done signal: You can describe, for each of the four most commercially significant lease provisions (maintenance reserves eligibility, redelivery conditions, subleasing consent, and return condition compensation), what the lessor’s standard position is, what the airline’s standard objection is, what the range of market-accepted compromises is, and what the residual commercial risk is for the lessor in the compromise position. You can describe one specific negotiation in which a provision was contested — naming the provision, the parties’ initial positions, the path to resolution, and the commercial consequence of the agreed language — without breaching confidentiality.

18. Build quantitative estimation fluency for aircraft leasing portfolio economics — lease rate factors, maintenance reserve adequacy, and portfolio return — without a financial model

4–5 hours

Skill: Senior-speed first-principles reasoning about aircraft leasing commercial viability

Why the field cares: Senior aircraft leasing professionals are expected to sanity-check lease rate proposals from the marketing team, estimate whether a proposed maintenance reserve rate is adequate for the lessee’s utilisation profile before the formal actuarial analysis is completed, and recognise when a portfolio concentration creates a stress scenario that changes the return profile from acceptable to problematic. These estimation problems are tractable from first principles: estimating the all-in lease rate that covers a lessor’s cost of funds plus required return at a given aircraft value; estimating whether the maintenance reserve balance will cover the projected shop visit cost at the current accrual rate and utilisation; estimating the portfolio’s stress loss in a scenario where 10% of lessees default simultaneously. None of these requires a detailed financial model — they require the governing commercial relationships applied with appropriate assumptions.

Done signal: You have worked through five aircraft leasing commercial estimation problems covering at least two of: the minimum lease rate factor at which a lessor with a stated cost of funds achieves its required return on a narrowbody aircraft at a stated value; the adequacy of a per-flight-hour engine reserve rate for a specific engine type given the lessee’s reported hours-to-cycles ratio; the security deposit required from a specified airline credit at a specified lease term to cover the expected maintenance reserve shortfall under a stress utilisation scenario; the off-lease carrying cost

for a narrowbody aircraft in the current market while transition maintenance is completed; and the portfolio return impact of a 5% default rate among the lessee book in a market-downturn scenario. You state your assumptions before numbers, identify the most load-bearing commercial assumption, and give order-of-magnitude answers with stated uncertainty.

4–5 hours

ALL LEVELS**19. Prepare a specific answer to “Why aircraft leasing — and why this specific role and employer?” that reflects genuine commercial and transactional engagement**

1–2 hours

Skill: Technically specific motivation that distinguishes leasing-committed candidates from those who find the sector interesting

Why the field cares: Aircraft leasing employers receive applications from candidates who are attracted by the combination of aviation and finance — two inherently interesting sectors. What they are looking for is professionals who understand the specific commercial challenges the sector faces and who have a specific professional contribution to make to addressing them — not professionals who want to work at “the intersection of aviation and finance.” The expected answer engages with one of: the portfolio management challenge of a specific aircraft type transition and how the candidate’s background applies to it; the cross-jurisdictional insolvency management challenge and what the candidate’s legal or transactional background enables; the maintenance reserve adequacy challenge for a specific engine type and how the candidate’s technical or actuarial background applies; or the aircraft remarketing challenge in the current placement environment and how the candidate’s market or negotiating experience is relevant. The answer must name one specific commercial challenge, explain what makes it complex, and connect the candidate’s specific background to contributing to its resolution.

Done signal: You have a 90-second answer that names the specific aircraft leasing commercial challenge most relevant to your background, explains what makes it hard (the specific gap in current market practice, the legal complexity, or the financial estimation difficulty), and connects your professional background to contributing to its resolution. The answer demonstrates that you have researched the specific employer’s current portfolio composition and can describe one specific challenge — a type concentration, a geographic exposure, or a specific lessee credit event — that your background is relevant to. The answer cannot be given unchanged to a candidate applying to any other leasing employer.

20. Map your professional background to a specific lessor type, role level, and commercial domain — and understand where each employer sits in the market

1–2 hours

Skill: Precise self-positioning in a sector where employer portfolio composition and market position matter more than in most finance disciplines

Why the field cares: The aircraft leasing sector in 2025 spans employers at completely different points in their commercial and portfolio cycle, and the professional work — and the candidate characteristics required — differs dramatically between them. AerCap is the world’s largest lessor with over 3,000 aircraft, a highly sophisticated portfolio management capability, and active structured finance and capital markets activity — a candidate targeting a role there is entering the most operationally complex and institutionally developed environment in the sector. Air Lease Corporation is publicly listed, marketing-focused, and operates primarily through new aircraft orders placed directly with Airbus and Boeing — a candidate targeting a marketing role there will work closely with manufacturer relationships and forward delivery positions. SMBC Aviation Capital is bank-owned, relatively conservative in credit terms, and has a strong position in the Asia-Pacific lessee market. A boutique fund such as Carlyle Aviation Partners or Castlake operates with a more opportunistic portfolio approach, targeting aircraft and leases that major lessors cannot or will not take — requiring a different risk appetite and analytical framework. A candidate who has not understood where each employer sits in the market — its ownership structure, its portfolio composition, its competitive differentiation,

1–2 hours

and its current strategic priorities — is not ready for the interview.

Done signal: You can state in under 60 seconds: the aircraft leasing employer you are targeting and its position in the market (portfolio size and composition, ownership structure, competitive differentiation, and current strategic priorities); the specific professional role you are targeting and why your background matches the employer’s current commercial needs; the specific aircraft types and lessee markets most relevant to your target employer; the commercial or legal tools and analytical methods you work in fluently; and one specific commercial challenge the employer is currently facing — derived from publicly available information (annual reports, conference presentations, investor presentations, court filings) — that your background is positioned to help address.

SUMMARY REFERENCE TABLE

#	Task Description	Target Level	Effort
1	Aircraft leasing ecosystem — lessor, lessee, lender, insurer, and inter-participant interactions	All	4–5 h
2	Cape Town Convention and International Registry — specific provisions, Alternative A, DPOA	All	5–6 h
3	Operating lease structure — maintenance reserves, redelivery conditions, default, total loss	All	5–6 h
4	STAR stories — transactional discipline, risk identification, counterparty management, learning	All	2–3 h
5	Aircraft types and commercial characteristics — narrowbody, widebody, regional leasing market	All	3–4 h
6	Read lessor annual reports and airline SEC filings — portfolio composition, lease disclosure	All	6–8 h
7	Airline insolvency — Section 1110, Cape Town Alternative A, international variation	Mid+	5–6 h
8	Maintenance reserve system — rate setting, eligible events, reconciliation, disputes	Mid+	5–6 h
9	Complex delivery or redelivery story — complication, exposure, resolution	Mid+	2 h
10	Aircraft finance structures — ECA, bank debt, capital markets, ABS structure	Mid+	4–5 h
11	Tax structure of aircraft leasing — Ireland, Section 110, IFRS 16, treaty networks	Mid+	4–5 h
12	Aircraft remarketing process — market assessment, transition maintenance, execution	Mid+	4–5 h
13	Cross-domain leasing portfolio problem — insolvency scenario or transaction structuring	Mid+	4–6 h
14	Portfolio management decision story — analysis, recommendation, and outcome	Senior	4–6 h
15	One active leasing frontier — narrowbody supply, aging widebody market, or SAF provisions	Senior	4–5 h
16	Portfolio strategy discussion — fleet type mix, geographic concentration, origination channel	Senior	4–5 h
17	Lease documentation negotiating points — maintenance reserves, redelivery, subleasing, compensation	Senior	4–5 h
18	Quantitative estimation — lease rate factors, reserve adequacy, portfolio stress, off-lease cost	Senior	4–5 h
19	“Why aircraft leasing — why this employer and role?” — commercially and transactionally specific	All	1–2 h
20	Employer market position / portfolio composition / commercial domain self-positioning	All	1–2 h

THE STRUCTURAL REALITY THAT MAKES AIRCRAFT LEASING DIFFERENT

Aircraft leasing is the only finance subdomain where the asset being financed flies — and where the asset's physical condition, maintenance history, regulatory status, and operational characteristics are as important to the transaction's economics as the borrower's credit profile would be in a conventional lending relationship. The lease structured on paper today will produce its financial consequences over a 12-year term across multiple jurisdictions, multiple maintenance events, and multiple market cycles that no one can accurately predict. The lessor who prices the maintenance reserves incorrectly will discover the error only when the shop visit invoice arrives, years after the lease was executed and long after any adjustment is commercially feasible. The lessor who accepts redelivery documentation that appears complete but is missing a back-to-birth trace on a life-limited part will discover the problem when the next lessee or buyer conducts their pre-delivery inspection and demands a substantial price reduction. And the lessor who has not understood the Cape Town Convention status in the lessee's jurisdiction will discover, in an insolvency, that its security interest is not enforceable in the way the transaction was structured to assume.

This combination — the long-dated financial commitment, the physical asset that must be tracked, maintained, and managed across the full commitment period, and the cross-jurisdictional legal framework that determines whether the financial position is ultimately enforceable — is the structural complexity that defines aircraft leasing and makes it genuinely different from every other asset finance discipline. In conventional lending, the credit analysis determines whether the borrower will repay. In aircraft leasing, the credit analysis, the asset analysis, the legal structure analysis, and the maintenance reserve adequacy analysis all determine the outcome simultaneously, over a time horizon long enough for any of them to be materially wrong.

The professionals who succeed in this environment are those who can hold the full picture explicitly in mind across the life of the transaction — who always know the maintenance reserve balance relative to the projected shop visit cost, the remaining lease term relative to the aircraft's residual value trajectory, and the lessee's credit trend relative to the lessor's exposure. They are also those who are genuinely curious about the asset — who want to understand the physics of why the engine performance deteriorates, the economics of why the narrowbody residual value is more stable than the widebody's, and the legal mechanics of why the Irish SPV structure provides a better financing outcome than a direct ownership model.

This curiosity — about the aircraft, the airline, the law, and the market cycle simultaneously — is the specific intellectual character that every serious aircraft leasing employer is trying to find in the candidates they hire, and it is what this document has been structured to help you demonstrate.

BREAK INTO AEROSPACE
